A B C vs S/N C

BROWN Sheridan Center for Teaching and Learning

Investigating Faculty Perspectives on Pass/Fail at Brown University

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Overview

Brown University's Satisfactory/No Credit (S/NC) grading option has allowed students to take any course pass/fail. However, limited research exists on faculty and staff's perspectives on this grade option. In this student-led research project, we explored how faculty and staff perceive the S/NC grading option. Through 22 faculty and staff interviews across 13 departments, we investigated how these views influence advising practices as well as how faculty and staff see students using the system. Our findings revealed a broad consensus on the value of S/NC as a tool for academic exploration and risk-taking. However, advising practices among faculty and staff varied: some advisors provided no resources to students, others relied on the advisor handbook, and some discussed the purpose of S/NC and its connection to students' academic goals. We aim to share these findings with faculty and staff at the College to inform institutional policy and enhance the undergraduate academic experience.

Key Definitions

- **S/NC:** A grade option in which students receive a grade of Satisfactory (pass) or No Credit (fail). Students may elect to take any course S/NC by the fourth week of the semester. Any number of courses may be taken S/NC by a Brown undergraduate.
- **Concentration:** A student's degree program. The Brown University term for "major."
- **Concentration Requirement:** A course that is required to receive a degree in a certain concentration.
- **ABC/NC:** The grade option in which students receive a grade of A, B, C, or No Credit.
- **SPW:** Stress, pressure, and worries.

Methods

Participants:
N = 22 faculty, staff, and deans from **13 departments** at Brown University were recruited via email outreach.

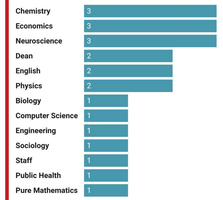
Data Collection:
Semi-structured interviews (30-45 minutes) were conducted between December 2024 and October 2025. At the end of each interview, all participants completed a survey.

Procedure:
Interviews were conducted either in-person or over Zoom, at the discretion of the interviewee. Survey data was collected with Qualtrics.

Data Analysis:
Transcripts were analyzed using inductive thematic coding. Codes were developed iteratively, with codes refined over multiple readings. Related codes were grouped into broader themes by comparing patterns across responses. A subset of transcripts was independently coded by multiple researchers, and discrepancies were resolved through discussion.

Departmental Affiliations of Interviewees

n = 22 faculty and staff interviewees



3 respondents = 14% , 2 respondents = 9%, 1 respondent = 5%
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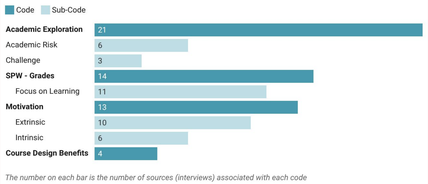
Results

The following section contains results from the faculty and staff interviews conducted for this study. Because this study was motivated by a previous study into students' decision-making process regarding S/NC, the Discussion section also includes references to the student data (see Survey Data for more information).

For the full codebook and relevant Brown-specific definitions, scan the QR code to the right ⇒

Faculty and Staff Perception of the Philosophy of S/NC

n = 22 faculty interviews thematically coded



The number on each bar is the number of sources (interviews) associated with each code
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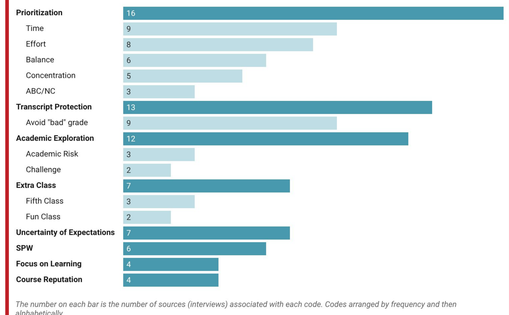
Faculty and Staff Perception of Student Application of S/NC

n=22 faculty interviews thematically coded



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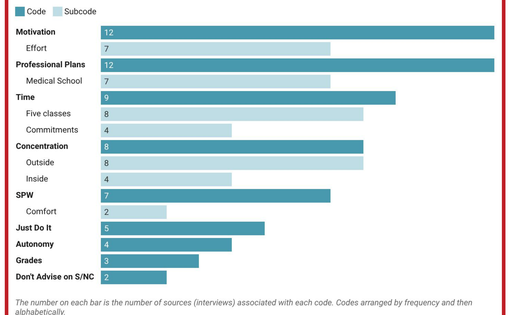
Factors Advisors Recommend Students Consider in S/NC Decision-Making

n=22 faculty interviews thematically coded



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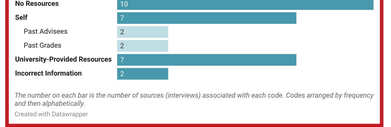
Resources Advisors Reference to Inform Advice on S/NC

n=22 faculty interviews thematically coded



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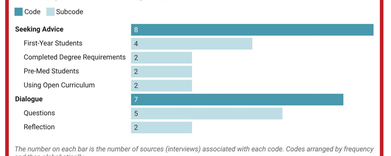
Advisors' Statements on Meetings with Students

n=22 faculty interviews thematically coded



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Faculty and staff view the philosophy of S/NC to be a tool for academic exploration.

A disconnect exists between philosophy and application: faculty see students using S/NC as a tool for prioritization and transcript protection rather than solely for exploration.

Advising around S/NC focuses on student motivations and professional plans, as well as time management.

However, advice varies due to inconsistent advising resources and varying experience with S/NC.

Faculty/Staff Quotes

"The general ethos at Brown about why S/NC exists as it does is to promote exploration in fields that you feel less comfortable in"

"[Students] are like, 'I don't trust this professor to have fair grading'"

"Don't do that [course] S/NC because a medical school or professional school will want to see that grade"

"From my students' perspective... a lot of students take a course S/NC if they think they're not going to get an A"

"The S/NC system was put in place to encourage people to take courses that are outside of their comfort zone. To take a class that they wouldn't necessarily take if they knew they were going to get a grade. Just to explore something new"

"I do advise against taking a course S/NC as part of a concentration requirement."

Key: Philosophy, Application, Advising

"I do think [students] largely see it as a way to help them try something new, so that they can go into a course, do their best."

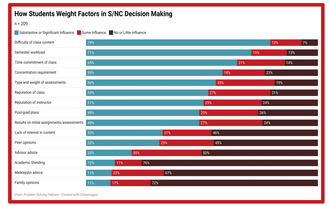
"I don't know...of a hard resource or something from the University [on S/NC], I don't think I have any?"

"The S/NC option gives the students an opportunity to free themselves from the grades...to explore a subject outside of their main area of interest, or to explore in their main area of interest at a level where they're truly learning the material for the sake of learning it rather than for the sake of chasing an A"

"It was the student who was not a concentrator... asked me if they should S/NC the class because they were worried. As someone who was outside of [the field], taking the class was intimidating"

Survey Data

For more information about the student data, scan the QR code to the right ⇒



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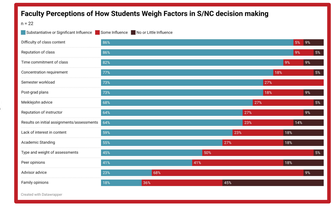

Discussion

The data suggests that the S/NC system operates in a negotiated space between institutional ideals and student realities. Faculty and staff promote a philosophy of academic exploration and intrinsic motivation, but advising practices and a lack of official S/NC resources often translate this philosophy into context-dependent, strategic guidance–often around professional plans and time management. We observe a disconnect between this philosophy and how faculty see students using S/NC: they see students using S/NC as a tool for prioritization and transcript protection in addition to using it for academic exploration. Advice given often centers on student motivations, professional plans, and time management; however advice varies because of a lack of widely used standardized advising resources.

A comparison of student and faculty/staff data suggests that faculty and staff generally recognize what factors are most important in students' S/NC decisions. However, they tend to attribute greater importance to these factors than students themselves, indicating an overestimation of how much certain considerations influence students' choices between ABC and S/NC.

Recommendations

Clarify and Communicate the Purpose of S/NC

The gap between philosophy and application suggests a need for clearer institutional messaging about what S/NC is for. This could include examples of "intended" uses (e.g., challenge, risk-taking) alongside acknowledgment of common strategic uses, which would reduce ambiguity rather than ignoring it.

Standardize Advising Resources and Training on S/NC

Given that many advisors rely on personal interpretations of S/NC or no resources at all, advisors and students would benefit from centralized, accessible advising materials with information about S/NC. This would reduce misinformation and create more consistent messaging to students across advisors.

Reduce Uncertainty Around Courses and Expectations

Since uncertainty of expectations and general anxiety surrounding certain courses influences S/NC decisions, increasing transparency in syllabi, grading practices, and course expectations (e.g., through standardized course information or student feedback summaries) could reduce reliance on S/NC as a hedge against the unknown.